

"No, not at all."

"Ah-ha! Then the old coot who doesn't pay his rent begged to be let off."

"Well, yes."

"And you softened? He begged you and you went mushy? That's a terrible way to do business. Why, if he'd tried that on me, I'd have—"

"He didn't beg *me* to let him off. He didn't say a word to me."

"Well, he certainly didn't beg *me*, so may I respectfully inquire to whom he did address himself?"

The lawyer said quietly: "He addressed himself to God Almighty."

"So he fell on his knees when you asked for the rent and he—"

"No. He didn't know I was there. It wasn't for *my* benefit. You see, I knocked on the door and nobody answered. The door was ajar. I thought the old couple might have left already, so I walked in. The place is pretty bare, and I found myself looking through a half-open door into a bedroom where a white-haired old woman was propped up in bed, on pillows. I was just about to clear my throat—let her know I'd come in—when she said to someone else in the room: 'I'm ready now. You go ahead, Pa.'"

"A man who was very old came from the other end of the room and knelt beside the bed. I couldn't move or say a word then, for the life of me. And that old man prayed, with his hand in the old woman's hand. First, he reminded God that they still were His submissive children, Ma and he, and no matter what He saw fit to bring upon them, they wouldn't rebel at His will. But it was going to be hard for them to be homeless in their old age, with Ma so sick and helpless, and, oh! how different it might have been if He had spared only one of their three sons, but the boys were no longer on this earth . . ."

The lawyer wiped at his eyes. "I cried then," he said, "but I still kept very quiet. And I listened to him remind the Lord about the safety of those who put their trust in the Lord, and how it wasn't going to be pleasant to go to the almshouse after a life of living together in a home of their own. And yet, he told the Lord, he knew there is such a thing as a just bargain with one's neighbor, and he ended by asking the Lord's blessing on . . ." The lawyer choked up.

"Not on *me!*" the property owner said hoarsely.